

HACKU 2026 Official Participant Handbook

Computer Science Association, The University of Hong Kong

Dates: 2 to 4 October 2026 | Venue: HKU Main Campus

1. Welcome & Quick Reference

Welcome to HACKU 2026!

Welcome to HackKU 2026! This is the official participant handbook for HackKU 2026.

What is HACKU 2026?

HackKU is Computer Science Association (CSA)'s flagship 48-hour inter-university hackathon. Now in its third year, we collaborated with HKIAIA (Hong Kong Information and Artificial Intelligence Association) to bring together 150+ talented students from universities across Hong Kong and top universities in Mainland China. Team up to solve real-world industry problems, build working prototypes, and showcase your skills to our elite company sponsors!

Thank You to Our HACKU 2026 Sponsors



Contact Details

Please save the following contact details in case of an emergency:

- HackKU-related Concerns: csa@cs.hku.hk, 9712 7346 (WhatsApp), 6166 9038 (WhatsApp)
- HKU 24-Hour Security Control Centre: 3917 2882
- Hong Kong Emergency Services: 999
- HKU CEDARS 24/7 Support: 3917 8388

2. Official Schedule & Venue

Schedule

Date	Time	Activity	Venue
Day 1: Fri, 2 Oct	11:15 – 12:00	Registration and Networking	HW312
	12:00 – 13:00	Opening Ceremony	HW312, UG207
	13:00	Hackathon Begins (Problem Statements Released)	All Venues
	14:00 – 15:00	SenseTime Workshop: From Messy Data to Meaningful Insight	HW312
	15:00 – 16:00	HKT Workshop: Building Trust for Autonomous Agentic Operation	HW312
	20:00	Track Declaration Deadline (via Google Form)	Online
Day 2: Sat, 3 Oct	All Day	Continuous Hacking	HW312
	10:00 – 12:00	SenseTime Helpdesk	HW312
	Throughout Day	Potential pop-up sessions	HW312
Day 3: Sun, 4 Oct	13:00	Submission Deadline & Code Freeze	Online
	13:00 – 13:30	Break	HW312
	13:30 – 14:30	FinTech Track Exhibition and Networking	HW312 & LE7, LE8, LE9
	14:40 – 15:40	Deep Tech Track Exhibition and Networking	HW312 & LE7, LE8, LE9
	15:40 – 16:15	Break and Finalist Selection	HW312 & LE7, LE8, LE9
	16:20 – 17:40	Finalist Pitching Round (Top 8 Teams)	LE1

	17:40 – 18:10	Company Spotlights	LE1
	18:10 – 18:50	Closing Ceremony and Prize Presentation	LE1

Opening Ceremony & Registration Details

- Opening Ceremony attendance is not mandatory, but is highly recommended.
- Registration will be open until Fri, 2 Oct 23:59, at least one team member in-person is required to register for your team.

Attendance Requirements

- At least one team representative must be physically present to register for your team on Day 1.
- At least one team representative must be physically present for your track's Exhibition.
- If your team advances to the Pitching Round, at least one team representative must be physically present to present your project on stage.
- Failure to meet these requirements will result in disqualification of your team.

How to Get to HW312

1. Exit HKU station by Exit A.
2. Take the elevator up to the campus.
3. Walk forward and turn right to the Haking Wong Building, follow the HacKU 2026 signage.
4. Enter through the rear door.
5. Take the elevator to Level 3.
6. Follow the HacKU 2026 signage to Room 312 (HW312).

How to Get to Library Extension Building (LE1, LE7, LE8, LE9)

1. Exit HKU station by Exit A.
2. Take the elevator up to the campus.
3. Walk forward and turn left to University Street.
4. Turn left, take the escalator down.
5. Walk to the end, turn left and go past the coffee shop.
6. Walk forward, take the stairs down beside the main library.
7. Follow the HacKU 2026 signage to the respective rooms.

3. Rules and Regulations

To ensure a fair, safe, and productive environment, all participants must adhere to the following rules.

Code of Conduct

- Professionalism: Participants must maintain a professional and respectful demeanour at all times.
- Zero Tolerance: Harassment, discrimination, or disruptive behaviour of any kind will result in immediate disqualification and removal from the venue.
- Compliance: All activities must comply with the laws of Hong Kong and HKU's policies on Civility on Campus, Equal Opportunity, and the Code of Academic Conduct.
- Cooperation: Participants must follow all instructions given by the HacKU Organising Committee, Campus Security, and University personnel at all times.
- Respect for Peers: Participants must respect the intellectual property and workspace of other teams. Snooping, unauthorised access to another team's devices, or copying another team's code is strictly prohibited and will result in immediate disqualification.

Team Rules

- Team Composition: Teams must consist of 3 to 4 accepted participants of HacKU.
- Adding Team Members/Forming a team (only for those registered as duos or individual): <https://forms.gle/HGTE6uZPoSUr7ujv6>
- Team Names: Team names must be appropriate in scope and professional. The HacKU Organising Committee reserves the right to contact team members and request modifications to inappropriate or inappropriate-scoped team names.

Code Rules

- Originality: All code submitted must be written entirely during the 48-hour hacking period. Pre-written code, templates, or boilerplate from previous projects are strictly prohibited.
- Open-Source Libraries: Open-source libraries and frameworks are permitted provided they are properly credited.
- AI Assistants: The use of AI coding assistants is permitted and encouraged; however, teams must be fully prepared to explain their core logic and system architecture to the judges.
- Third-Party Services: Teams are responsible for any costs incurred while using third-party APIs, cloud hosting, or external services during the hackathon. We highly recommend utilising free tiers or sponsor-provided credits. The Organising Committee is not liable for any unexpected charges.

Venues

Participants must observe the following rules at all times while using the designated venues (including but not limited to LE1, LE7, LE8, LE9, HW312, UG207 and any other rooms allocated for the event):

- Food and Drink: Eating and drinking are strictly prohibited inside all venues. Refreshments may only be consumed in designated open areas outside the rooms.
- Cleanliness: Participants must keep the venues clean and tidy at all times. All rubbish must be properly disposed of in the bins provided. The HackKU Organising Committee reserves the right to impose a cleaning charge on teams that leave excessive mess.
- Furniture: Participants may rearrange free-standing chairs and tables within the venue as needed. However, furniture must not be removed from the room or taken outside the venue. All furniture must be returned to its original arrangement at the end of the event (or as instructed by the organisers).
- AV/IT Equipment and Power: Do not tamper with, modify, or damage any AV/IT equipment, projectors, screens, sockets, or fixtures.
Normal use of power sockets for charging personal devices (laptops, phones, etc.) is permitted, provided that:
 - Only one device is plugged into each socket where possible
 - No multi-plug adaptors or high-power devices that may overload the circuit are used without prior approval
 - Cables do not create tripping hazards
- Property Protection: Participants must not cause any damage to University property, including walls, floors, furniture, equipment, or fittings. Any damage caused by a participant or team may result in the team being held liable for repair or replacement costs.
- Conduct and Safety:
 - Running, rough play, or any disruptive behaviour inside the venues is prohibited.
 - Do not obstruct doorways, corridors, or emergency exits.
 - Follow all instructions given by the HackKU Organising Committee, Campus Security staff, and University personnel.
- Personal Belongings: Participants are solely responsible for their personal belongings. Do not leave valuables unattended. The University and the Organising Committee accept no liability for any loss or damage.
- Visitor & Guest Policy: The hacking venues are strictly for registered HackKU participants, judges, registered guests and HackKU Organising Committee members. Unregistered guests, friends, or family members are not permitted in the hacking venues at any time.
- General: Smoking and vaping are strictly prohibited on the entire University campus. Failure to comply with these rules may result in disqualification and/or removal from the venue.

Deposit Refund Policy

To receive the full HK\$25 per person deposit refund, the following requirements must be met:

- Submission of project to the provided Google Form, and
- More than 50% of the team members must be physically present at the Closing Ceremony.

To receive the full HK\$12.5 per person deposit refund, the following requirements must be met:

- Submission of project to the provided Google Form, or
- More than 50% of the team members must be physically present at the Closing Ceremony.

General & Dispute Resolution

- Final Authority: In the event of any dispute regarding the rules, judging, or event operations, the decision of the HackKU Organising Committee and the respective judging panels shall be final and binding.

4. Terms and Conditions

- Intellectual Property (IP): All IP rights arising from code, designs, concepts, prototypes, or documentation created during the hackathon remain the sole and exclusive property of the participating team. Neither the Organising Committee nor any sponsor claims ownership. Any post-hackathon collaboration or commercialisation discussions shall be conducted solely between the sponsor and the team; the Committee assumes no liability for such arrangements.
- Media Consent: By participating, you consent to the capture and use of your photographs, video, and audio recordings by the Organising Committee and its authorised representatives for event documentation, promotion, and publicity (including social media, website, and printed or digital materials). Recordings may also be shared with official event sponsors and partners. Sponsors may engage their own photographers at the event for their independent promotional purposes; the HackKU Organising Committee does not control and is not responsible for such recordings. Participants who do not wish to be featured may notify a member of the HackKU Organising Committee upon arrival to be directed to a designated no-recording area.
- Data Privacy: Personal data provided during registration (including CVs and profile details) will be used for event administration and may be shared exclusively with official event sponsors for recruitment and evaluation purposes. You may withdraw this consent at any time by emailing csa@cs.hku.hk. Please note that withdrawal applies only to future sharing; the HackKU Organising Committee is not liable for data already distributed to sponsors prior to your request.
- Limitation of Liability: To the maximum extent permitted by law, the Organising Committee and HKU assume no liability for any direct, indirect, or consequential damages, personal injury, or property loss (including laptops and equipment) arising from participation in the event.
- Eligibility Verification: The Organising Committee reserves the right to verify the student status and identity of any participant at any time. Falsification of identity, team composition, or student status will result in immediate disqualification and forfeiture of any prizes or deposits.
- Force Majeure (Weather & Emergencies): In the event of a Typhoon Signal No. 8 or above, a Black Rainstorm Warning, or other unforeseen emergencies, the event schedule, venue, or operations may be suspended, modified, or cancelled. Updates will be communicated promptly via the official WhatsApp and WeChat groups.
- Right to Modify: The Organising Committee reserves the right to modify the schedule, rules, or venue arrangements if necessary. Any material changes will be communicated promptly via email, the official WhatsApp and WeChat groups.

5. Tracks, Problem Statements & Submission Guidelines

Track & Problem Statement

- Tracks: HackU features two main tracks: FinTech and Deep Tech.
- Problem Statements: There are two problem statements under each track. The specific problem statements for each track will be officially released at 13:00 on Day 1.
- Track Declaration Deadline: All teams must submit their track selection via the Google Form (released at the Opening Ceremony) by 20:00 on Day 1. Failure to submit will result in disqualification.

Submission Guidelines

- Deadline: Sunday, 4 October 2026, at 13:00 Hong Kong Time.
- Code Freeze: All code must be committed to your repository before this time.
- Required Deliverables:
 1. A public GitHub or GitLab repository link.
 2. A live demo link or 3-minute recorded video demonstration.
 3. Pitch Deck
- You may include visual supplemental materials such as a poster.
- All materials must be publicly viewable.
- Submission Portal: Submissions must be made via the official HackU Submission Form, which will be released on Day 2.
- Late Submissions: No late submissions will be accepted under any circumstances. Please submit early to avoid technical issues.

6. Awards & Opportunities

Overall Awards

- First Place: The Club by HKT Gold — HKD 7,000
- Second Place: HKU Computer Science Silver — HKD 4,000

- Third Place: Qube Research & Technologies Bronze — HKD 3,000
- Incubation Opportunities: The winners of the Overall Awards (ALL TOP 3) may receive an exclusive opportunity from WriteTalent to further incubate their projects.
- Finalist Perks: The Top 8 finalists that advance to the Pitching Round of the Overall Awards will receive a Certificate of Distinction, and souvenirs from SenseTime.
 - Those who submitted the Raccoon Work: Every member receives a specially customized "SenseTime Little Raccoon" gift bag (containing a custom Raccoon Work badge, a custom self-adhesive wrap cloth, a custom eye mask, and a seasonal membership card).

Sponsor Awards

The Club by HKT Innovation Award

- Prizes: HKD 7,500 (awarded in Clubpoints, redeemable for equivalent spending value on The Club mobile app and website)
- Eligibility Requirements: The team must declare that their project is addressing the sponsored FinTech problem statement set by HKT.
- Award Overview: Presented to the most outstanding project addressing the sponsored FinTech problem statement set by HKT.
- Special Opportunity: The winning team may be invited to further develop their project in collaboration with or under HKT, subject to a separate agreement between the team and HKT.
- Resources & Guidance: An official workshop will be hosted by HKT to talk about their current products and ecosystem, help participants better understand their evaluation criteria, business expectations, and future vision.

Raccoon Work Technical Sponsor Award

- Prizes: Each member receives a specially customized "SenseTime Little Raccoon" gift bag (containing a custom "Challenger" badge, a custom throw pillow, a custom eye mask, and a one-year membership card). This is an additional award (limited to one winning entry) selected from all projects created using the "SenseTime Little Raccoon" platform; it is distinct from the awards for the competition finalists, meaning a team can win this in addition to other prizes.
- Award Overview: Presented to the team that demonstrates the most innovative and effective integration of SenseTime Raccoon in their hackathon project.
- Eligibility Requirements: Projects must incorporate SenseTime Raccoon to qualify for this prize. Teams must include a brief declaration explaining how SenseTime Raccoon was utilised within their submission form.
- Resources & Guidance: Full technical details and instructions for SenseTime Raccoon can be found in the SenseTime Raccoon Redemption Code Guide. An official workshop will be hosted by SenseTime to provide additional information, tips, and guidelines.

Certificate of Participation

- All participants who successfully submit a project will receive a digital Certificate of Participation.

7. Judging Process & Criteria

Overall Awards Judging Criteria

The judging process consists of two rounds:

- Exhibition: All participating teams will showcase their projects during the track exhibitions. Projects will be evaluated by our panel of Technical Judges. The Top 8 teams, as determined by the Technical Judges, will advance to the Pitching Round.
- Pitching Round: The Top 8 finalist teams will present their projects on stage. Projects will be evaluated by our panel of Pitching Judges.

Exhibition — 30 Marks

1. Problem & User Needs — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Problem is unclear, insignificant, or unrelated to user needs.
2	Problem is identified but poorly defined; limited understanding of users.
3	Clear and relevant problem with basic understanding of target users.
4	Well-defined problem supported by strong understanding of user needs and context.
5	Highly important and clearly validated problem with deep insight into users and underlying needs.

2. Solution & Human-Centered Design — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Solution poorly addresses the problem; little consideration of users.
2	Partially addresses the problem but user experience or user flow is weak.
3	Reasonable solution with generally usable and logical user experience.
4	Effective solution with intuitive, thoughtful and user-centered design.
5	Excellent solution deeply aligned with user needs; highly intuitive, inclusive and well-designed experience.

3. Technical Implementation — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Little or no functional technical implementation.
2	Basic implementation with major technical issues or inappropriate technology choices.
3	Core technology works with reasonable implementation and some limitations.
4	Strong technical implementation with appropriate tools and reliable functionality.
5	Excellent, robust and well-designed implementation with strong technical reasoning.

4. Prototype & Demonstration — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Prototype does not work or fails to demonstrate the solution.
2	Limited prototype with major bugs or incomplete core functions.
3	Core functions work and the main concept can be demonstrated.
4	Stable and effective prototype clearly demonstrating the solution.
5	Highly polished and convincing prototype that clearly proves the solution works.

5. Innovation & Creativity — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Copies existing solutions with little or no originality.
2	Minor improvements to existing approaches.
3	Some creative features or combinations of existing ideas.
4	Clearly innovative approach or creative application of technology.
5	Highly original and distinctive solution demonstrating exceptional creativity.

6. Practicality & Impact — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Little practical value or realistic application.
2	Potential use is identified but feasibility or impact is weak.
3	Reasonably practical with clear potential real-world application.
4	Strong feasibility, practical value and meaningful potential impact.
5	Highly feasible and scalable with significant real-world value and strong future potential.

Pitching Round — 30 Marks

1. Problem Framing & Relevance — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Problem is unclear, irrelevant, or unsupported.
2	Problem is identified but broad or weakly justified.
3	Clear and relevant problem with basic supporting context.
4	Well-defined and important problem supported by convincing evidence or examples.
5	Highly significant problem with excellent framing, evidence, and insight into root causes.

2. Market / Competitive Understanding — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	No awareness of existing solutions or competitors.
2	Mentions alternatives with little comparison.
3	Identifies relevant alternatives and basic differences.
4	Strong comparison showing clear gaps and opportunities.
5	Excellent competitive understanding with a highly convincing unique positioning.

3. Solution Effectiveness & Value Proposition — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Solution does not meaningfully address the problem.
2	Partially addresses the problem but lacks key elements.
3	Workable solution with a clear basic value proposition.
4	Strong solution that clearly addresses the problem and delivers meaningful value.
5	Highly convincing solution with strong problem-solution fit and clear, distinctive value.

4. Innovation & Differentiation — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Little or no originality.
2	Minor modification of existing ideas.
3	Some novel features or creative combinations.
4	Clearly innovative and differentiated approach.
5	Highly original, distinctive, and compelling innovation.

5. Pitch Structure & Delivery — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	Unclear, disorganized, and difficult to follow.
2	Basic structure but unclear or unconvincing delivery.
3	Clear and logical pitch with acceptable delivery.
4	Well-structured, engaging, confident, and professional.
5	Exceptionally clear, persuasive, engaging, and memorable pitch.

6. Impact, Feasibility & Future Vision — 5 marks

Score	Description
1	No realistic impact, feasibility, or future direction.
2	Limited impact or future potential; major feasibility concerns.
3	Reasonable impact and feasible next steps identified.
4	Strong real-world potential with realistic growth and risk considerations.
5	Highly compelling impact with strong feasibility, scalability, risk awareness, and future vision.

The Club by HKT Innovation Award Judging Criteria

Criterion	Weight	What it assesses
Problem–solution fit	25%	Does it actually address the problem statement sponsored by HKT?
Technical execution and working prototype	25%	Does it run? Code quality, architecture, agent reasoning, complexity
Security and trust design	15%	Authentication, authorisation, consent, auditability, failure handling
User experience and desirability	20%	Is the journey usable and compelling, especially for Gen Z?
Feasibility of integration with any payment means	15%	Assessed on the realism of the proposed payment rails alone — including but not limit to Mastercard, UnionPay and Faster Payment System (FPS).

Raccoon Work Technical Sponsor Award

Criterion	Weight	What it assesses
Effective Use of Raccoon Work	30%	Meaningful use of Raccoon Work in research, data analysis, content creation, coding, or other project tasks. Teams should briefly demonstrate how it contributed to their work and outcomes.
Implementation & Completeness	30%	How well the prototype or deliverable works, including its completeness, reliability, and validation of AI-generated outputs.
Innovation & Creativity	20%	Originality of the idea and thoughtful use of AI to address the chosen problem.
Practical Value & Potential Impact	20%	Clarity of the target users and problem, usefulness of the solution, and potential for real-world application.

8. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

Q: Can I change my team members after registration?

A: Yes, but only before 13:00 on Day 1. Please fill in the google form:

<https://forms.gle/HGTE6uZPoSUr7ujv6>. You do not need to fill in this form if your team is exactly the same as declared in the initial sign up form.

Q: What if I can't attend the Opening Ceremony?

A: On-site attendance is not mandatory, but it is highly recommended. However, please note that welcome souvenirs are distributed during this time, and you may miss out if you are not present. The registration desk will also remain open throughout Day 1 so you can still register. Your teammates can register for your team, but if you come on-site you will still need to register yourself so we can give you a lanyard.

We will also be hosting a Zoom Meeting for the Opening Ceremony. The details for the Zoom Meeting can be found below:

Topic: HackU 2026 Opening Ceremony

<https://hku.zoom.us/j/99481164330>

Meeting ID: 994 8116 4330

Q: Are the workshops optional?

A: The workshops are optional, but we highly recommend participants to join them as they may provide important insights into how to win the Sponsor Awards. Please note that the workshops will not be recorded.

Q: Must I stay for the entire hacking duration?

A: No, we do not track attendance during the 48-hour hacking period. You are free to come or leave at any time. However, we strongly encourage your team to stay on-site to maximise collaboration, access support, and make the most of the event.

Q: What if I can't attend the Exhibition or Pitching Round?

A: Please make sure at least one team member must be physically present at your team's exhibition booth and during the pitching round (if your team is selected as a finalist). If no representative is present, your team will be disqualified from the competition.

Q: What if I can't attend the Closing Ceremony?

A: Our Deposit Refund Policy requires that more than 50% of your team members be physically present at the Closing Ceremony to receive your deposit back. Please note that refunds will only be distributed on-site at the end of the event.

Q: When will the problem statements be released?

A: The problem statements will be released at 13:00 on-site, and will also be sent directly to your registered email.

Q: Is there accommodation for participants?

A: Unfortunately, we do not provide accommodation for participants. However, HW312 will be open overnight.

Q: Where can I sleep if I stay overnight?

A: You may sleep at HW312, which will remain open overnight. If necessary, please bring your own sleeping bag, mat, or blanket, as well as a jacket, as the air conditioning remains on.

For further inquiries, please email csa@cs.hku.hk or reach out to the HackU Organising Committee via the official participant WhatsApp or WeChat groups.

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